is back in action, playing a significant role in the turnaround. In Haryana, the BJP was faced with a decade-long anti-incumbency, burnt-out cadre and an untested state leadership. It was up against a Congress led by two-time chief minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda, an almost perfect Jat-Dalit-Muslim caste combo working for it, and was armed with a loaded narrative of the angry "*kisan-jawan-pehalwan* (farmer, soldier, wrestler)". Turning the tables on this combination was no easy task, but the BJP managed it, winning 48 of the 90 seats and a clear majority in the state.

THE RSS HAND

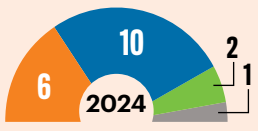
For the current round of assembly polls, the party had put together a formidable team in June. It included Union ministers Dharmendra Pradhan (along with former Tripura CM Biplab Deb) to oversee Haryana, Shivraj Singh Chouhan (along with Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma) for Jharkhand and Bhupender Yadav (along with cabinet colleague Ashwini Vaishnaw) for Maharashtra. The party leadership also sensed that their core voters and sympathisers harboured a sense of guilt over the Lok Sabha election outcome that had weakened PM Modi's position. A key reason for that was that many BJP leaders had fallen out of step with the RSS, believing the party organisation had outgrown its mentor. Realising its folly, the BJP top brass sought the RSS's help again to rebuild trust with the voters.

HOW THE BJP WON

A regionwise break-up of the party's strategy to sidestep a decade of anti-incumbency and the resurgent Congress narrative

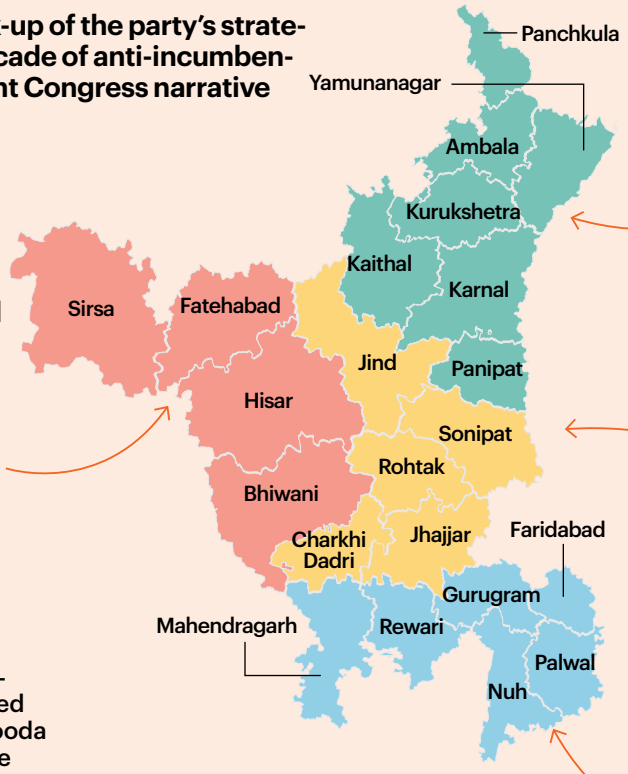
BAGAR REGION

Total seats: 19





BJP Cong INLD JJP Others



KEY FACTORS

- The party successfully countermobilised the non-Jats after Hooda promised to open the Shambhu border for the protesting Punjab farmers
- Gurmeet Ram Rahim, the jailed 'godman' who enjoys maximum clout here, backed the BJP
- But with the Chautalas' influence now restricted to Sirsa, their Jat support base seems to have largely moved Congressward in other districts

The BJP effectively deployed its 'forward-backward' formula to neutralise the Congress's Jat-Muslim-Dalit coalition in the state

Accordingly, RSS sah-sarkaryavah Arun Kumar and Pradhan were entrusted with the task of mobilising the cadre to mount a low-decibel, targeted campaign in Haryana. Arun Kumar's RSS colleagues, Atul Limaye and Alok Kumar, were asked to do the same in Maharashtra and Jharkhand, respectively. In Haryana, between the RSS and its affiliates, a group of 150 volunteers was formed for every constituency, which held about 100 meetings a week with small rural gatherings. Along with messages on nationalism, Hindutva and the policy corrections by new CM Nayab Singh Saini, they also pushed the narratives of "*kharchi-parchi*" (jobs scam) and "*damaad-dalal*" (land scams) during the previous Opposition regimes.

Meanwhile, on another front, the BJP was also countering the Congress's damaging '*kisan-jawan-pehelwan*' campaign, which had been boosted by Olympian wrestler Vinesh Phogat's candidature from the Jat-dominated Julana seat in Jind district. If Vinesh won by a narrow margin, it was only because the BJP did not allow the Congress offensive to grow into a larger women- and youth-centred movement. Instead, it managed to portray it as Hooda's ploy to fuel the anger of the Jats against the BJP community. Ditto for the ex-CM's promise of opening up the Shambhu border and allowing the protesting Punjab farm unions to reach Delhi. The Congress had not declared Hooda as their CM choice, but it could scarcely disguise the fact that it was he who was calling the shots, which again helped the BJP in its anti-Jat consolidation.

Hooda had hoped the unhappy Jats,